

Figure 5: VirtuaGym showing a gym machine workout

Figure 6: VirtuaGym teaching indoor/floor exercises

want to do. Once you add a workout, you are presented with choices—not only basic floor and free-hand exercises, but even full-fledged gym exercises. On selecting an exercise, you are greeted with an image of it. Here, you can choose the text-based version (showing you the proper steps) by clicking the ‘i’ icon on the top right—or you can play the animated clip for a clear view of the exercise sequence. The animation is very smooth and displays all the necessary positions for the exercise. The software even guides you through the number of sets and repetitions needed for that particular exercise. Once you complete an exercise set, a timer tells you to get ready for the next set. The app even teaches you the breaks you need to take during each exercise session, which is very nifty indeed. However, during my testing, it failed to alert me with an audible alarm, even though the option was enabled.

Upon completing the exercise, the timer appears again, showing you the rest time you should take before starting another exercise. VirtuaGym is a complete personal training app, and I am thrilled to be able to use it for my training schedule. Other than a few glitches here and there, the app does the job right.

Calorie counter-MyFitnessPal

A proper diet is a must for a healthy body and mind. An appropriate diet control can lead to balanced and quick weight loss or gain. This requires a balanced intake of calories, nutrients and vitamins. MyFitnessPal helps with that. The very well-integrated diary that is synced online, the weight-measurement tool and calculator provide an estimate on your progress. It works well, and is a boon for the diet-conscious “people”.

The interface may not be the best, but it isn’t gaudy, and provides a plethora of options to manage your diet and daily routine. The bonus is that the app provides you a brief overview of your calorie stats and gives you a glimpse of how you will look a few weeks later, if you

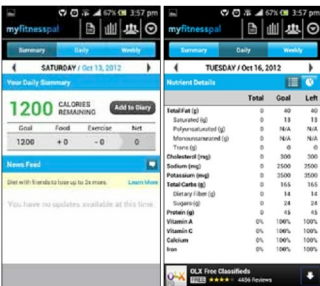


Figure 7: The MyFitnessPal home screen

Figure 8: Calorie chart showing total calorie consumption

continue using the app effectively. The app has an efficient bar-code reader to read the calories of what you are eating (of course, irrelevant if you are eating home-cooked food—this feature makes more sense in Western countries where they tend to eat more packaged foods). This is a major drawback for Indian users of the app; it’s tough for a layman to calculate calorie intake for home-cooked meals. To compensate for this, the app has a great online database on food; if you ate three *chapatis*, you can search for *chapati* and add up your caloric intake from there. Items that are not available can be added manually. Overall, the app is a must-have for the health-conscious.

Limbering down

Apps like the above have a few missing bits that will soon get sorted out with future revisions, so don’t get disheartened if you find some features missing. Using the apps properly can give you an A-class training experience without even hitting a gym. Productive and helpful apps like these exercise your smartphone and you! **END**

References:

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